

Vienna Secession

Art nouveau in Austria and Germany was sometimes called *Sezessionstil* (Secession style) after the Vienna Secession, a group of painters, sculptors and architects who opposed the conservatism of the Künstlerhaus (home to the Association of Austrian Artists), and who took inspiration instead from the linear style of Mackintosh. In 1897, led by Gustav Klimt (1862–1918), they broke away from the Künstlerhaus and formed their own group. They put on exhibitions and produced a magazine, *Ver Sacrum* (Sacred Spring), extolling their beliefs and aims.

Architects in the group were Otto Wagner, Josef Hoffmann (1870–1956) and Joseph Maria Olbrich. Mixing industrial materials with ornamentation, Secession architecture was often strongly rectilinear, based on clean and simple geometric forms with decorated façades, commonly featuring curving lines and shapes (Horta's whiplash or 'eel' line was popular). Wagner, the eldest of the group's architects, declared: 'Nothing that is not practical can be beautiful.'



Karlsplatz Station in Vienna, Wagner, 1899